daughter Zila Hamdi. Mariam came for treatment for a heart condition, and explored the possibility of getting her eleven-year-old daughter Nisha, too, educated here. Much later, a CBI report that found the ISRO spy case false, mentioned that Fauziyya first came to India as an interpreter for a businessman from Sri Lanka, and Mariam had the intention of meeting her old lover, a doctor from Kozhikode.

Earlier, Mariam was an agent for the National Security Service of the Government of Maldives and was in India to gather information about some people who were believed to be planning a coup against the Government of Maumoon Abdul Gayoom.

At the airport, the customs officer extracted $100 from Mariyam. The Maldivian kept cribbing about the ‘extortion’ when she was overheard by a co-passenger, K Chandrasekhar, a Bangalore-based Indian representative for Russian space agency Glavkosmos. Playing the hero and trying to help the damsel in distress, Chandrasekhar quarreled with the customs officer and got back the money for Mariam.

He struck a conversation with a thankful Mariam who tried to take as much advantage of the helping hand as possible. She told him that she had a heart problem for which she needed to consult a doctor. Also, on her wish list was a school admission for her friend Fauziyya’s daughter and her own daughter.

Chandrasekhar promised to deliver on everything. In Bangalore, he took Mariam to meet his friend S K Sharma who was also a labour contractor. Sharma’s uncle K L Bhasin was a retired brigadier, an influential person who could be tapped for the school admission. Bhasin was later to be mistaken for or misrepresented as Kerala I G Raman Srivastava by the Intelligence Bureau. Bhasin and Sharma met Chandrasekhar and Mariam at a club in Bangalore where Sharma promised to get admission for Fauziyya’s daughter. As for a doctor for Mariam, Chandrasekhar suggested the name of Sasikumaran’s wife. Later Sasikumaran met Mariam.

In Bangalore, Mariam Rasheeda stayed with Fauziyya at Sara Palani’s house where Fauziyya was a paying guest. As Fauziyya Hassan was having difficulty in getting admission for her daughter in a good school, and the